



THE FOURTH IMPACT

Fourth Impact

*A declaration on digital responsibility as the new dimension of
business value*

ECONOMIC • SOCIAL • ENVIRONMENTAL

+ Digital ★

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THE FOURTH IMPACT MANIFESTO · VF26

FOUNDATION

For decades, business theory and practice learned that the value of an organization cannot be reduced to its financial results. The triple impact paradigm —economic, social, and environmental— represented a conceptual and ethical advance of the first order.

That model remains valid. But the world it inhabits has substantially changed. Organizations must adapt to this new reality.

The emergence of artificial intelligence, the automation of cognitive processes, and the massive digitalization of operations represent not only a technological trend but also a radical shift in the very nature of work, decision-making, and human organization. Organizations today operate both in physical territories and in symbolic systems, data flows, and algorithmic environments that shape behaviors and build —or destroy— human fabric.

Faced with this reality, the triple impact is necessary but insufficient. It lacks a dimension that must be attended to in order to avoid ethical, strategic, and cultural cost.

Technology and artificial intelligence are powerful instruments — accelerating, transformative — based on the human decisions that design, implement, and direct them.

The Fourth Impact is the responsibility of organizations for how they integrate, use, and distribute the power of technology and artificial intelligence. It is not a technical matter, but one of judgment, values, and collective purpose.

This manifesto establishes the fourteen principles that guide a way of thinking and building organizations for an era that simultaneously demands greater efficiency and greater humanity.

An ethics for the age of artificial intelligence



I

Technology is the tool, and people are the engine.

There is confusion in the discourse of digital transformation: the tendency to treat the incorporation of technology as if it were in itself the goal of transformation. That perspective inverts the correct order of things.

No profound transformation begins in a software nor a platform. It begins with people: in their willingness to learn, their ability to adapt to change, to question established processes, and their commitment to integrate the new without losing what is essential.

Technology can accelerate processes. But people are the ones who provide direction, meaning, human judgment, and limits.



II

Digital responsibility is the new business ethics.

Just as the triple impact paradigm extended corporate responsibility toward economic, social, and environmental dimensions, the Fourth Impact extends that responsibility to the digital domain. It is an obligation that emerges from the very nature of the power that technology confers.

Digital responsibility implies transparency about data use, ethical judgment in the design of automations, awareness of algorithmic biases, and genuine protection of privacy.

Not everything that can be automated should be automated. And whatever is automated must be done with broad criteria of ethics and responsibility.



III

Artificial intelligence must expand human intelligence,
not replace it.

Artificial intelligence is extraordinarily capable of recognizing patterns and processing information. But it lacks situated judgment, ethical sensitivity, and the ability to ask the right questions before answering them. It works with what already exists, from what has already been created by human intelligence.

Its highest value lies in liberating human capacities: time from repetitive tasks, energy from inefficient processes, access to large volumes of information at speed — all so that human thinking can focus on what is irreplaceable.

The work of AI is not to think for us. It demands that we think better, with more depth, and about more relevant questions.



IV

Automating without strategy is institutionalizing disorder.

There is a well-documented trap in accelerated digital transformation processes: the tendency to automate existing processes without questioning them first. When an inefficient process is automated, it accelerates the inefficiency with less visibility.

The Fourth Impact holds that technological transformation requires a previous work of organizational understanding: mapping real processes, systematizing, standardizing with judgment, and identifying the value and the waste.

First understanding. Then design. First judgment. Then tool.



V

Adaptability is the strategic competency of the century.

The systems that survive turbulent environments are not the largest nor the most powerful, but those most capable of learning and reconfiguring. The speed of technological change has turned this observation into a first-order operational requirement.

In business contexts, adapting means developing the institutional capacity to read weak signals, revise assumptions, and incorporate contradictory information without being paralyzed. It means abandoning the idea of building things "forever" and developing a flexible mindset from day one: every thing that is designed must be built to change.

In the digital age, resisting change is also a decision. It usually is the most expensive one.



VI

Efficiency must serve wellbeing, not be at its expense.

One of the least debated risks of mass automation is its potential to intensify working conditions under the guise of optimization. When technology eliminates friction, it can also eliminate the recovery margins that make human work sustainable over time.

A truly intelligent organization uses technology to free itself from operational and repetitive tasks, in pursuit of developing creativity and adding value through human functions. Wellbeing is the biological and ecological condition that allows an organization to remain competitive, adaptable, and innovative over time. Protecting human recovery margins is strategic.

Productivity without humanity is not efficiency. It is deferred exhaustion.



VII

Human capabilities are the most important technology of any organization.

The more powerful the capabilities of systems, the more value is added to those skills that systems cannot replicate: critical thinking, creativity, empathy, leadership, assertive communication, and ethical judgment in ambiguous situations.

When artificial intelligence absorbs much of the "doing" — repetitive tasks, data processing, standard response generation — people undergo an identity transition that organizations cannot ignore. The Fourth Impact declares that "empowered humanity" also means learning to value people for inhabiting ambiguity, facilitating meaningful conversations, and making decisions with human judgment.

The future will not belong to those who know only how to use tools. It will belong to those who know how to think, decide, communicate, and lead better with them.



VIII

Deep thinking requires protection.

The logic of digital immediacy structurally changes modes of thinking: it displaces sustained attention in favor of rapid reaction, and it turns superficiality into the only possible register of thought.

Organizations have the responsibility to protect spaces for pause, conversation, and reflection. Because that is where the system processes, distills learning, and prevents alienation. Healthy dialogue with technology requires the previous capacity to sustain genuine dialogue with oneself and with others.



Using artificial intelligence well is not asking it to think for us. It is learning to dialogue with it without surrendering our own voice.



IX

Leading technological transformation is, above all, a human responsibility.

Digital transformation is not simply implementing a system. It occurs when people in an organization change their way of thinking with technology, working, deciding, and relating. And that change is not decreed: it is accompanied, explained, and cared for.

The leaders who navigate well the AI era are those who communicate clearly the why before the how, listen to resistance without dismissing it, and understand that organizational trust is not built by the leader alone toward the team: it is a mutual support network woven across all levels of the organization, especially in times of uncertainty and accelerated change. Digital transformation is, at its core, a collective project.

Healthy technological adoption requires trust. And trust is not installed with technology. It is built with leadership and sustained with reciprocity.



X

Technology must expand opportunities, not deepen inequalities.

Technological development has a structural tendency that must be countered: that of concentrating its benefits among those who already possess capital, access, and knowledge, and its costs among those who lack them.

Building inclusive teams, designing accessible tools, and reducing gaps are acts of coherence with a business project that proclaims itself responsible.

Digital inclusion is not access to tools. It is access to understanding, participation, and opportunity.



XI

Well-led technological transformation strengthens organizational identity.

There is a legitimate fear facing digital transformation: that incorporating technology will erode the culture or service style that constitutes the identity of the organization.

When transformation is well led, exactly the opposite occurs: technology frees people from the tasks that do not define them, so they can devote greater intensity to those that do.

Adopting technology is not losing identity. It is enhancing the best of an organization with new capabilities.



XII

The future is not AI or humans. It is humanity
empowered by technology.

Technology and artificial intelligence are instruments: powerful, accelerating, transformative — based on the human decisions that design, implement, and direct them.

The most important question is not whether artificial intelligence will replace people. It is what kind of people, leaders, and organizations we want to be in an era where our capabilities can be expanded by technology. The Fourth Impact proposes that organizations use AI to help but not govern, where data guides but does not dehumanize; where efficiency matters but not more than wellbeing; and where people are valued not only for what they produce, but for who they are and the human quality with which they inhabit their roles.

The future will not simply be digital. It will be human or it will not truly be the future.



XIII

Data confidentiality is a human right, not a technical option.

Organizations that operate with people's data assume a responsibility that goes beyond legal compliance. Data is assets that contain stories, vulnerabilities, decisions, and connections of real people.

An organization committed to the Fourth Impact protects data with the same judgment it would apply to any other fundamental right, because it understands the ethical weight of what it holds.

Organizations that use people's data have the obligation to protect it, explain its use, and ensure it is never an instrument of violation.



XIV

Technology must operate within the limits of the planet,
not at its expense.

Digital transformation has an environmental dimension that few organizations measure and even fewer manage: the energy consumption of data centers, the accelerated obsolescence of devices, the carbon footprint of large-scale artificial intelligence models. Ignoring that impact only makes it invisible.

A Fourth Impact organization understands that using technology responsibly also means questioning its environmental cost. It is not about renouncing innovation, but about ensuring that digital progress does not advance at the expense of the planet that sustains it. Technological efficiency and environmental sustainability, when designed together, enhance each other.



The intelligent organization does not only measure what it produces. It also measures what it consumes, what it emits, and what it leaves behind.

— FINAL DECLARATION —

*A call to build organizations that deserve the
future they claim to want.*

The Fourth Impact is not a manifesto against technology. It is a manifesto about the responsibility that comes with it. About the difference between using the power that artificial intelligence confers consciously or unreflectively.

The triple impact taught us that an organization cannot grow ignoring society, the environment, or economic sustainability. The Fourth Impact completes that vision for our time. Because nowadays an organization must also account for the way it uses technology, data, automation, and artificial intelligence.

Artificial intelligence can be a threat when used without judgment. It can be a fad when used without strategy. But it can also be an extraordinary ally when integrated with responsibility, efficiency, and wellbeing.



Let us be four-impact organizations.

Organizations that generate economic value.

Organizations that elevate people.

Organizations that care for the planet.

Organizations that use technology with conscience.

Let us be Fourth Impact leaders.

Not to adapt to the future in any way we can.

But to design it responsibly.

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